Weekly Bulletin of IT News and Articles

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Department of Strategy and Analysis
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ANALYSIS

1. Digital rights and technological sovereignty raised to a constitutional mandate in Kazakhstan

(Kazakhstan mass media)

15 March referendum in Kazakhstan is about to rewrite roughly 84% of the national constitution. According to the exit polls released in the early hours of March 16, the "Yes" vote is sitting at around 87%, with a solid voter turnout of 73%.

The new constitution, set to take effect on 1 July 2026, elevates digital rights and technological sovereignty to a constitutional mandate. It is designed to provide the "legal floor" for the Digital Code *(signed in January 2026)* and the **Law on Artificial Intelligence** *(effective as of January 18, 2026).*

The most significant shift is the constitutionalization of digital rights. Thus, for the first time, "digital profile" is recognized as a personal, non-property interest. This gives citizens constitutional standing to sue or seek redress if their digital identity is misused.

The draft introduces a requirement for "transparency and non-discrimination" in automated decisions. This means the state *(and private companies)* can no longer hide behind 'black box' algorithms when they affect citizens' legal rights.

The "New Kazakhstan" model aims to move away from "Astana-only" development by empowering regional hubs. Thus, the constitution now allows for Special Legal Regimes to be established in "rapidly developing cities" beyond just the Astana International Financial Center. This effectively allows cities like Almaty or Shymkent to create similar centers of their own with distinct administrative and judicial rules to attract tech investment.

Intellectual property is now explicitly enshrined at the constitutional level. For a startup founder, this provides a stronger guarantee that software code and proprietary algorithms are safeguarded under Kazakh jurisdiction, making the country a more "predictable" place for venture capital.

The new draft *(Article 6.5)* significantly tightens the rules on foreign funding. While intended to limit political interference, startups and NGOs with heavy foreign backing will face much stricter public disclosure requirements.

The new draft accelerates the concept of "Technological Neutrality". Thus, the constitution supports the Digital Code's goal of moving the tech sector out of legal 'gray areas'. It provides the framework for experimental legal regimes *(sandboxes)* where AI and fintech startups can test products without being hampered by legacy laws.

Since the new parliament *(the Kurultai)* is unicameral and the President's bills now have priority, tech-related legislation – like the upcoming **Law on Digital Assets** – can be

passed in a maximum of 60 days. This 'fast-track' legislative capability is intended to keep pace with the speed of global tech changes.

Kazakhstan's new constitution represents a pioneering approach to digital-era governance, permanently embedding IT sovereignty, algorithmic transparency, and digital property rights directly into its foundational law. By shifting to a fast-track unicameral parliament capable of passing priority tech legislation within 60 days, and by decentralizing regulatory sandboxes across multiple urban hubs, the state is aggressively engineering a highly agile and legally predictable environment for domestic tech investment. While the stringent new rules on foreign funding introduce a layer of compliance friction for international venture capital, the overarching constitutionalization of digital rights signals that Kazakhstan is attempting to leapfrog traditional legal frameworks to become the most advanced, legally secure tech and AI hub in Central Asia.

2. Building the AI economy: inside Kazakhstan's new digital strategy

(El.kz)

Today, a new suite of artificial intelligence and digital economy tools – ranging from educational programs and startup accelerators to browser-based AI development platforms – was unveiled at Astana Hub. This event marks a pivotal moment in Kazakhstan's broader national strategy: the transition from merely adopting technology to fostering a full-scale National AI Ecosystem spanning education, science, business, and governance.

The heart of this transformation is the Alem.ai International AI Center. This multifunctional venue serves as the intersection for:

Scientific Research: Collaborative laboratories with global tech giants for Big Data and Large Language Model *(LLM)* development.

Startup Growth: A gravitational pull for regional developers, investors, and researchers.

Export Ambitions: Government projections suggest that by 2030, Kazakhstan's export of AI-driven products could reach billions of dollars. Education: Training Millions Kazakhstan is betting big on human capital to fuel its AI economy. The scale of the educational rollout is unprecedented:

Youth Focus: Educational spaces within Alem.ai allow teenagers to study generative AI, robotics, and game dev, while the Tomorrow School utilizes a peer-to-peer, project-based learning model to solve the shortage of qualified developers.

One of the highlights of the presentation was Alem Plus, a platform designed to democratize AI development. The Concept: Allowing individuals to build tech products without a massive engineering team. The platform offers low-code and no-code tools for speech/text processing, image generation, and cloud computing. "Our goal is

for anyone with a browser to be able to start creating AI solutions," says AI advisor **Ilyas Makash**.

The Astana Hub cluster now connects over 2,000 participants. To boost this sector, the state is loosening the reins on government contracts:

"AI'preneurs" Accelerator: A dedicated track for teams to develop AI products and secure seed investment. Restrictions on startups participating in state tenders are being lifted, allowing small tech firms to build data analytics and automation tools for the public sector. New Architectural Portals of the e-government system allow businesses to see which state databases are digitized, which systems are obsolete, and where new solutions are needed.

What does a "National AI Strategy" look like for the average citizen?

Hyper-Efficient Services: Faster processing of government requests and healthcare diagnostics. Thousands of high-paying jobs in the tech sector, reducing the brain drain.

Precision Agriculture: AI-driven farming to stabilize food security and costs.

For decades, Kazakhstan's growth relied on the commodities sector. Today's shift toward AI is a strategic move to leapfrog into the global knowledge economy. By treating education, the state, and business as an integrated technological platform, Kazakhstan is attempting to move from being a consumer of global tech to an exporter of its own algorithms and data assets.

These are not just investments in software; they are investments in the economic structure of the next decade.

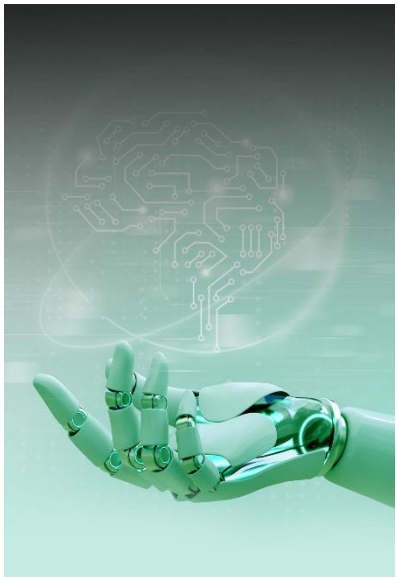
Kazakhstan is strategically pivoting its economic foundation from traditional commodities to the global knowledge economy. By tightly integrating education, business incubation, and government infrastructure, the nation aims to transition from a consumer of global tech into a competitive exporter of its own AI algorithms and data assets over the next decade.

(Read full article at https://el.kz/ru/kak-kazahstan-stroit-ekonomiku-iskusstvennogo-intellekta-chto-stoit-za-novoy-tsifrovoy-strategiey-strany_400045078/)

3. The government has the problem. A GovTech has a solution. Nobody introduced them

(UNDP)

Research indicates that approximately 85% of e-government projects in developing countries fail to achieve their objectives. According to the UNDP Resilience Hub for Africa, the root cause is structural: a massive disconnect between African governments facing urgent administrative challenges and a thriving continent-wide GovTech ecosystem capable of solving them. Governments typically communicate in policy terms, while tech firms use engineering language, leading to mismatched procurement processes that favor foreign solutions unsuited to local contexts over highly adaptable, locally built platforms.



To bridge this gap, the UNDP launched the Africa Digital Transformation Solutions Brokerage initiative. The program operates through highly deliberate phases:

Deep Mapping: Granularly mapping specific government pain points, mandates, and budgets across 46 Sub-Saharan countries, while simultaneously tracking the capabilities of local GovTech companies.

Structured Challenge Articulation: Moving away from vague aspirations, governments define specific, bounded operational bottlenecks *(e.g., digital identity, health records, public financial management)* that tech companies can directly respond to.

The "Nairobi Moment": A highly curated matching event where GovTech companies pitch customized, context-ready prototypes directly to the government officials who own the challenges. Rather than a standard hackathon, it acts as a platform to co-design implementation pathways and mobilize blended financing for projects ranging from $ 250,000 pilots to $ 120 million national infrastructure rollouts.

Africa's digital transformation hurdle is not a lack of technology or talent, but a critical absence of institutional brokerage. By creating a structured, heavily vetted marketplace that translates government policy needs into actionable tech briefs, the UNDP's brokerage initiative effectively aligns public sector demand with local GovTech supply, transitioning governments from fragmented digital aspirations into fully operational, citizen-serving systems.

(Read full article at https://www.undp.org/africa/resilience-hub-africa/blog/government-has-problem-govtech-has-solution-nobody-introduced-them)

CIS NEWS

4. The Central Asian country rewriting the rules on women's rights

(Euronews)

Uzbekistan has jumped 51 places in the global Gender Equality and Governance Index, from 103rd to 52nd, as a sweeping legislative overhaul embeds equality provisions across the constitution, the national development strategy and more than 110 separate legal acts.

The World Bank's 2026 Women, Business and the Law report ranks Uzbekistan 48th out of 190 economies, up 43 places, with a legal framework score of 82.1 out of 100, above the global average of 67. The country achieved maximum scores in mobility, family, pay, childcare and asset rights, with further gains in labour and pension legislation.

Women now hold 38% of seats in the Legislative Chamber, 27% in the Senate and 32.5% in local councils, following the 2024 parliamentary elections.

Women now make up 54% of Uzbekistan's higher education student body – over 904,000 enrolled as of 2026 – and account for 61% of interns, research assistants and PhD students…

Uzbekistan is also an outlier in digital education: according to Coursera's Gender Gap in Generative AI analysis, it is the only country where women make up the majority of generative AI enrolments, at 58.9%.

Uzbekistan is aggressively dismantling systemic barriers and reshaping its legal framework to champion gender equality. Through comprehensive legal reforms, heightened political inclusion, and a strong emphasis on advanced education, the nation is rapidly closing the gender gap and uniquely positioning its female population to lead in forward-looking, high-tech fields like artificial intelligence.

(Read full article at https://www.euronews.com/business/2026/03/09/the-central-asian-country-rewriting-the-rules-on-womens-rights)

5. Tokayev champions AI revolution

(Akorda)

President **Kassym-Jomart Tokayev** has chaired a high-stakes working session at the Akorda to overhaul the Digital Qazaqstan strategy, signaling a shift from basic digitization to a deep, AI-driven state transformation.

The meeting laid out a bold roadmap for what Tokayev is calling the "Year of Digitalization and AI".

In a candid critique of the current system, the President warned that while 90% of government services are online, the "back-end" remains clogged by red tape.

"Digitalization and bureaucracy are as incompatible as ice and fire," Tokayev remarked. "**We must stop trying to hammer nails with a microscope. A modern digital state must be adaptive to AI and navigate Big Data with ease. My goal is simple: it is data that should run, not people**."

With the Digital Code and the **Law on Artificial Intelligence** already in force, Tokayev emphasized that the legal groundwork is set, but the execution must accelerate. He expressed anxiety over the global pace of AI development, urging the government to shake off any perceived sluggishness.

In G2B/G2C transformation, the Ministry of AI must lead by example, the President insisted, fully transitioning to a new interaction format with citizens and businesses by the end of 2026.

With regard to the AI-Sana Initiative, the head of state demanded "concrete results" from the national AI program to ensure Kazakhstan remains a regional leader.

The strategic launch of two national supercomputers was highlighted as essential for "technological sovereignty".

In accordance with the directive, department heads will be personally accountable for data quality, officially treating government data as a critical economic asset.

Furthermore, with a new regulatory framework for the crypto industry set to go live in May, the President ordered a balanced plan to grow the digital asset market while aggressively combatting fraud and illegal capital flight.

Dwelling on the constitutional referendum, Tokayev linked high-tech progress to human rights. He stated that if the new Basic Law is approved, the protection of personal data will move from a mere regulation to a constitutional duty, ensuring that innovation does not come at the cost of citizen privacy.

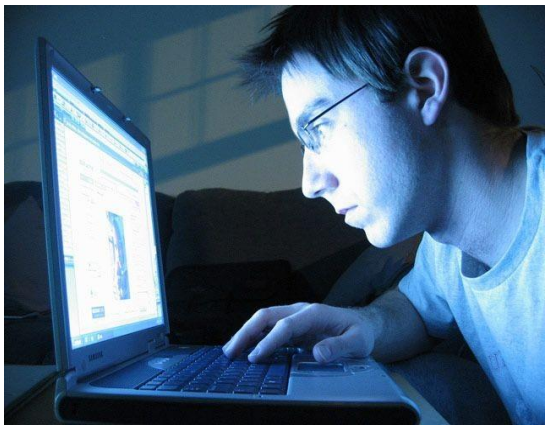
"Every data leak undermines trust in the state," Tokayev concluded. "In the era of AI, security is not optional."

Kazakhstan is highly transitioning its e-government infrastructure into a fully autonomous, algorithmic administrative state. By legally codifying artificial intelligence, deploying sovereign computing power, and preparing to elevate data privacy to a constitutional level, the government is treating digital transformation as a matter of national security and economic survival. This top-down mandate forces a rapid modernization of the public sector, aiming to eliminate bureaucratic friction while firmly cementing Kazakhstan as the dominant, secure technological and crypto-regulatory hub in Central Asia.

(Read full article at https://www.akorda.kz/ru/glava-gosudarstva-provel-soveshchanie-po-proektu-digital-qazaqstan-1325054)

6. Global internet freedom rankings: Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan far ahead of Eurasian neighbors

(The Times of Central Asia)



The 2026 Global Internet Freedom Rankings, published this week by the research agency Cloudwards, have revealed that the five countries of Central Asia have significantly less internet censorship than all of their Eurasian neighbors. Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan's online environments emerge as particularly encouraging cases.

Cloudwards defines internet censorship as the banning or restricting of online content or services, such as social media platforms, VPN apps, and certain political or religious messaging. It also covers the more welcome deletion of harmful content. Censorship can be done by governments, or initiated by a country's internet service providers and other businesses.

Cloudwards' research scored 171 countries on a scale of 0-100, rating their overall levels of internet censorship using five key criteria: torrenting availability; adult content accessibility; social media platforms; access to varied political and religious content; and VPN regulations.

Eleven nations returned the highest score of 92, including New Zealand, Belgium and Timor Leste. While North Korea scored 0, the next four worst countries for internet censorship – each scoring just 4 – all border Central Asia: China, Pakistan, Iran and Russia.

Tajikistan's score of 56, while only middling in the global context, means that its internet is subject to significantly less interference than almost anywhere in the wider Eurasia region. The Times of Central Asia reported last year that the country has repealed a law that allowed citizens to be prosecuted for 'liking' posts on social media that are critical of the government.

The only Eurasian country to rival Tajikistan is its northern neighbor Kyrgyzstan, which has the second freest internet in Central Asia, scoring 52 in Cloudwards' ranking. For comparison, 52 is also the overall score given to the United Kingdom and Brazil.

Kazakhstan scored 36 – above Singapore and South Korea, which both received a mark of 32. Uzbekistan scored 24.

While Turkmenistan's mark of 16 places it firmly among the world's worst countries for internet censorship, this is nonetheless higher than countries including India and Turkey *(both 12)*. Turkmen netizens still experience fewer restrictions than internet users in the aforementioned China, Pakistan, Iran and Russia.

The stark contrast in internet censorship between Central Asia and its bordering superpowers presents a significant strategic and economic advantage for the region's rapidly growing IT sector. By maintaining relatively open digital borders, lenient VPN regulations, and accessible social media ecosystems, countries like Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, and Kazakhstan are actively positioning themselves as viable, uncensored hubs for digital nomads, international data routing, and tech startups. This regulatory divergence essentially allows Central Asia to operate as an accessible digital bridge in a broader Eurasian landscape that is otherwise dominated by highly fragmented and state-monitored internet infrastructures.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/global-internet-freedom-rankings-tajikistan-kyrgyzstan-far-ahead-of-eurasian-neighbors/)

7. Competition in Russian IT has reached its maximum

(Habr)

According to data from the HeadHunter platform analyzed by "Dialectic," the Russian IT labor market is currently experiencing an unprecedented level of competition among job seekers due to a massive reduction in employer offers. In January 2026, the market index, which measures the ratio of active resumes to open vacancies, surged to an extreme high of 21.3, up from just 9.9 in January 2025. Over the past year, the total number of available IT vacancies plummeted by 39%, with a particularly severe drop of over 50% in inclusive hiring positions for people with disabilities. Concurrently, the candidate pool has expanded, with the total number of resumes increasing by 30% compared to two years ago. A financial gap between expectations and offers further highlights this cooling market, as candidates expect an

average monthly salary of 100,000 rubles while companies are offering approximately 94,500 rubles. This rapid shift from a talent shortage to a candidate surplus, driven by overall industry transformation and mass layoffs by major tech players, has firmly established an employer's market where companies can dictate much stricter hiring terms. However, it is noted that these average statistics may mask underlying imbalances, as the industry might still face severe talent shortages in specific, highly specialized roles despite the overall surplus of general candidates.

The Russian tech sector has undergone one of the fastest historical transitions from a candidate-driven environment to a definitive employer's market, characterized by shrinking job opportunities and a swelling applicant pool. As major tech companies revise their hiring strategies and tighten their budgets, job seekers face intense competition and downward pressure on starting salaries. While the overarching trend points to a significant market cooling, the employment landscape remains deeply fragmented, highlighting a structural imbalance where an oversupply of certain IT professionals coexists with localized deficits in highly specialized technical disciplines.

(Read full article at https://habr.com/ru/news/993828/)

8. Belarus creates legal framework for Bitcoin and crypto banks in new Decree

(BitcoinMagazine)

Belarusian President **Alexander Lukashenko** has officially signed Decree No. 19, titled "On Cryptobanks and Certain Issues of Control in the Field of Digital Tokens," which establishes a comprehensive legal framework for bitcoin and crypto banks in the country. This decree aims to position Belarus as a hub for financial technology innovation by offering a regulated environment for a hybrid financial model that blends traditional fiat banking *(deposits, loans, transfers)* with digital token operations.

Under the new law, a "crypto bank" is defined as a joint-stock company residing in the Belarus High-Tech Park *(HTP)* and listed in a special registry by the National Bank of Belarus. These entities will operate as non-bank financial institutions subject to strict dual regulation. They must comply with traditional banking standards, including capital adequacy, risk management, consumer protection, and anti-money laundering *(AML)* laws, as well as rules set by the HTP Supervisory Board. This move builds on Belarus's history of pro-crypto policies, including its 2017 tax-free conditions for crypto mining and trading, and aligns with its plans to launch a full-scale digital ruble in late 2026.

By creating a legally defined and tightly regulated path for hybrid "crypto banks," Belarus is actively integrating digital asset management with its traditional banking infrastructure. This strategic framework not only legitimizes cryptocurrency operations under strict state oversight but also aims to reduce financial friction and attract international fintech innovation to the country.

(Read full article at https://bitcoinmagazine.com/news/belarus-creates-framework-for-bitcoin)

GLOBAL NEWS

9. Punjab aims to develop Mohali as a tier 1 IT hub *(India)*

(The Times of India)

During the concluding day of the Progressive Punjab Investors' Summit 2026, the Punjab government announced its resolute goal to elevate Mohali into a Tier-1 Information Technology *(IT)* hub by strengthening the foundational pillars of governance, academia, and infrastructure, while actively integrating artificial intelligence into local manufacturing processes. To attract tech enterprises, the state introduced a suite of robust incentives under the Industrial and Business Development Policy 2026. These comprehensive benefits include significant fiscal perks such as a 75% net SGST reimbursement and a 100% electricity duty exemption for 10 to 15 years. Furthermore, the government is offering a capital subsidy of up to 20% of Fixed Capital Investment *(capped at Rs 10 crore)*, alongside employment generation subsidies of Rs 5,000 per employee per month for five years – a figure that increases to Rs 7,500 for the first 10 Global Capability Centres. To streamline ease of doing business, the state is also providing non-fiscal advantages like fast-tracked clearances within 5 to 45 days, complete exemption from the Punjab Apartment and Property Regulation Act *(PAPRA)* 1995 for all IT parks, relaxed setbacks, and unlimited Floor Area Ratio *(FAR)* on roads with a 45-meter Right of Way.

The Punjab government is aggressively positioning Mohali as a premier destination for digital innovation by combining highly competitive financial subsidies with swift regulatory exemptions and targeted infrastructure support. If executed effectively, these progressive policies are poised to attract massive corporate investments, generate substantial local employment, and successfully establish Mohali as a mainstream Tier-1 tech city.

(Read full article at https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/chandigarh/punjab-aims-to-develop-mohali-as-tier-1-it-hub/articleshow/129591939.cms)

10. Ministry engages stakeholders on Uganda's National Emerging Technologies Strategy

(Ict.go.ug)

The Ministry of ICT and National Guidance in Uganda recently convened a stakeholder engagement involving government, academia, the private sector, and innovation experts to collaboratively develop the country's National Emerging Technologies Strategy. Supported by the National Information Technology Authority-Uganda and AI Uganda, the initiative focuses on adopting and governing rapidly evolving digital technologies, such as Artificial Intelligence *(AI)*, Blockchain, Cloud Computing, Big Data Analytics, and Quantum Computing, to accelerate national development and economic growth. Permanent Secretary Dr. **Aminah Zawedde** emphasized that this strategy aligns with Uganda's broader Digital Transformation Roadmap, focusing on fundamental pillars like digital infrastructure,

cybersecurity, and data ecosystems, while prioritizing localized solutions such as native-language tech inclusion. According to Commissioner Ambrose Ruyooka, the strategy initially started as a Cabinet directive for an AI policy but was broadened to encompass various interconnected technologies designed to act as enablers for priority sectors under the Fourth National Development Plan, including agriculture, tourism, and manufacturing. Guided by international standards from organizations like UNESCO, the framework will also rigorously address ethical use, governance, infrastructure, and responsible deployment.

Uganda is taking a proactive and inclusive approach to digital transformation by developing a comprehensive National Emerging Technologies Strategy. By engaging diverse sectors and prioritizing foundational data governance and ethical standards, the government aims to position the country not just as a consumer of global tech, but as a responsible creator of localized digital solutions that drive cross-sector economic growth.

(Read full article at https://ict.go.ug/media/news/ministry-engages-stakeholders-on-ugandas-national-emerging-technologies-strategy)

11. A quarter of businesses deploy ICT to use materials sustainably

(Statistics Netherlands)

Recent figures from Statistics Netherlands *(CBS)* and Eurostat reveal that the Netherlands is among the top five EU member states for utilizing Information and Communication Technology *(ICT)* to promote sustainable material use. In 2025, 23% of Dutch businesses deployed ICT solutions, such as software for automatic waste sorting, 3D printing to minimize waste, and systems to reduce stock levels, to make their material consumption more sustainable, placing the country fourth in the EU behind Malta, Lithuania, and Belgium. Additionally, 21% of Dutch enterprises utilize ICT for energy reduction via smart thermostats and efficient lighting. The push for sustainability is highly prominent in specific industries; one-third of businesses in the energy, water, and waste management sectors use these technologies, whereas the accommodation and food services sector lags at 14%. Furthermore, the Netherlands ranks second in the EU for responsible e-waste management, with 90% of businesses sustainably disposing of old ICT equipment *(up from 73% in 2022)* by utilizing electronic waste collection points or returning items to suppliers, while 53% choose to keep obsolete equipment for spare parts.

Dutch businesses are increasingly leveraging ICT solutions to drive environmental sustainability, demonstrating strong adoption rates in both material efficiency and responsible electronic waste disposal compared to the broader EU average. While adoption varies significantly by industry and company size, the overall trajectory indicates a strong national commitment to integrating digital tools into corporate circular economy practices.

(Read full article at https://www.cbs.nl/en-gb/news/2026/11/a-quarter-of-businesses-deploy-ict-to-use-materials-sustainably)

12. Kenya reaffirms commitment to ICT consumer protection

(Communications Authority of Kenya)

On World Consumer Rights Day, marked globally on March 15, the Communications Authority of Kenya *(CA)* issued a press release reaffirming its robust commitment to safeguarding and empowering consumers within the country's rapidly evolving communications ecosystem. Aligning with the 2026 global theme, "Safe Products, Confident Consumers," the CA highlighted its active strides in advancing consumer protection in the digital economy. Key initiatives spearheaded by the regulatory body include providing effective, accessible redress mechanisms for consumer complaints across multiple regional offices and dedicated contact channels. The CA is also heavily focused on creating a safer internet experience for minors through its Child Online Protection programme and ensuring digital inclusivity for persons with disabilities by enforcing the ICT Accessibility Standards *(KS 2952)*. Furthermore, the authority leverages the Universal Service Fund to bridge the digital divide by expanding ICT connectivity to underserved communities. To guarantee product safety and reliability, the CA enforces rigorous Type Approval functions for ICT devices and empowers citizens to verify the authenticity of mobile phones using an IMEI Verification Checker.

The Communications Authority of Kenya is actively cultivating a secure, inclusive, and trustworthy digital marketplace through a combination of stringent regulatory standards, digital accessibility mandates, and direct consumer empowerment tools. By calling for collaborative efforts among government agencies, industry stakeholders, and the public, the CA aims to balance technological innovation with the fundamental protection of consumer rights and safety.

(Read full article at https://www.ca.go.ke/press-release-ca-reaffirms-commitment-protecting-ict-consumers-world-marks-consumer-rights-day)

13. China offers massive subsidies to boost OpenClaw AI adoption nationwide

(Habr)

The Chinese government is heavily incentivizing the adoption of the open-source AI agent "OpenClaw," elevating it to a matter of state strategy under the "one-person company" concept. In Shenzhen's Longgang district and Wuxi's Xinwu high-tech zone, authorities have launched massive subsidy programs offering up to 10 million RMB *($ 1.4 million)* in venture funding, partial coverage for implementing "digital employees" and hardware, along with free housing, office discounts, and free computing power for solo tech founders. This policy has sparked massive public demand, with thousands queuing outside Tencent's

headquarters for free installations and a booming paid-installation market emerging on platforms like Taobao.

Major cloud providers, including Tencent, Alibaba, JD, ByteDance, and Baidu, are aggressively pushing one-click OpenClaw deployments. Their primary motivation is to recoup an estimated $ 60 billion invested in AI infrastructure; unlike standard chatbots, OpenClaw acts as a "token black hole," capable of consuming up to 50 million tokens per user daily. However, this rapid, state-backed rollout carries severe cybersecurity risks. The Ministry of Industry and Information Technology has warned of potential data leaks, while security researchers have already discovered tens of thousands of unauthenticated agent instances and over 1,000 malicious packages *(roughly 20% of the ecosystem)* within its marketplace.

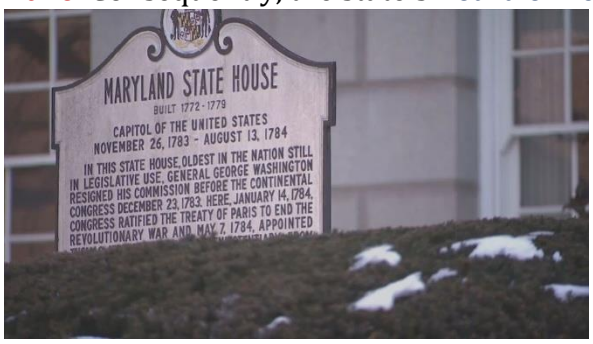
China is aggressively integrating the OpenClaw AI agent into its national economic framework to stimulate technological entrepreneurship and monetize massive idle investments in AI infrastructure. While these lucrative subsidies are successfully driving rapid, widespread adoption across the population, the breakneck pace of deployment is outpacing security measures, creating critical cybersecurity vulnerabilities and data risks that the government and developers must urgently address.

(Read full article at https://habr.com/ru/news/1008466/)

14. Maryland's IT tax misses forecasts, fueling conversations about future

(Foxbaltimore)

Maryland's recently enacted 3% tax on IT, data, and software publishing services is severely underperforming its revenue targets. Originally implemented to help close a $ 3.3 billion structural budget gap, the tax was projected to generate nearly $ 500 million in its first year. However, it collected only about $ 35 million during the first half of Fiscal Year 2026. Consequently, the state's Board of Revenue Estimates *(BRE)* has sharply downgraded the full-year projection to just $ 110 million, less than a quarter of the initial forecast. While roughly 2,900 companies have filed and officials assert that major tech firms are complying, the exact reasons for the muted earnings remain unclear. Experts suggest potential causes include "cost shifting" by companies adjusting prices elsewhere or a lack of awareness among smaller startups. Although an unexpected surge in estate taxes has temporarily offset the loss, leaving the state with a $ 355 million surplus for the current fiscal year, the IT tax's massive underperformance has contributed to a $ 108 million downgrade in the revenue forecast for the next fiscal year.



The dramatic revenue shortfall of Maryland's new IT tax has sparked intense debate over its overall viability and economic impact. With the tax failing to deliver the promised financial relief and state lawmakers facing looming multi-billion-dollar deficits in the coming years, there is growing momentum among critics and legislators to either heavily revise or fully repeal the measure before it further suppresses local tech business growth.

(Read full article at https://foxbaltimore.com/news/local/marylands-it-tax-misses-forecasts-fueling-conversations-about-future)

15. Google overhauls its Maps app, adding in more AI features to help people get around

(Apnews)

Google has unveiled a major architectural redesign of its Maps application, deeply integrating its advanced Gemini 3 AI model to transform how its 2 billion global users navigate and interact with spatial data. The overhaul introduces two primary technological features: "Ask Maps," a conversational AI tool that synthesizes unstructured data from 300 million places and half a billion contributor reviews to generate highly specific, context-aware recommendations and complex multi-stop itineraries; and "Immersive Navigation," which upgrades traditional driving directions into real-time, three-dimensional renderings of terrain, landmarks, and road medians. To ensure navigational reliability, Google has specifically fortified its AI guardrails to prevent geographical "hallucinations," a common generative AI flaw where models fabricate non-existent locations or data. Initially rolling out in the U.S. *(and India for Ask Maps)* across iOS, Android, CarPlay, and Android Auto, this upgrade also features intelligent algorithmic route analysis and predictive parking assistance.

This sweeping overhaul signifies Google's strategic transition from providing basic navigational utility to offering proactive, conversational spatial intelligence. By embedding the powerful Gemini 3 model directly into Maps, following similar high-stakes integrations in Chrome and Gmail, Google is aggressively leveraging its unmatched, decades-old geographical data moat to fend off rising competition from AI rivals like OpenAI and Anthropic. Ultimately, this integration not only fundamentally alters the user interface of digital mapping but also quietly lays the groundwork for a highly lucrative, entirely new category of localized, AI-driven conversational advertising.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/google-maps-ai-gemini-update-1933c40eaecfdbb9aa54d8ae3efcec2e)

Events calendar for IT PARK UZBEKISTAN, RESIDENTS OF IT PARK UZBEKISTAN and MINISTRY OF DIGITAL TECHNOLOGIES – *(March 2026)*

IT PARK UZBEKISTAN					
Date	**Event name**	**Description**	**Location**	**Event holder**	**Official Website**
Mar 16	Exploration of applied competencies	Regional integration workshop with EU universities to bridge knowledge gaps in the Central Asian talent pool.	Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Digitech	digitech.kg
Mar 17	Sourcing Spotlight on India	BME webinar exploring global procurement corridors, helping IT Park map competition and partnership routes.	Germany *(Online)*	BME Matchmaking	bmematchmaking.com
Mar 17-19	Union of Industrialists & Entrepreneurs Expo	Strategic exhibition in Ashgabat. IT Park can promote its "Local2Global" expansion initiatives to Turkmen businesses.	Ashgabat, Turkmenistan *(Offline)*	Chamber of Commerce	turkmenistaninfo.gov.tm
Mar 18	AI & Process Automation: Spend to Measurable Value	An executive webinar on adopting AI in BPO workflows; ideal for IT Park to shape its "AI-ready workforce" marketing.	Online	Datamatics	https://www.google.com/search?q=datamatics.com
Mar 23-26	Kube Con 2026	Cloud Native flagship event. IT Park infrastructure managers can explore edge-computing tech for local data centers.	Amsterdam, Netherlands *(Online)*	CNCF	nebius.com
Mar 24	Sourcing Social: Service Provider User Group	GSA UK session. IT Park leadership engages with UK buyers to shape the "Emerging Locations" outsourcing narrative.	UK *(Online)*	GSA UK	gsa-uk.com

Mar 24-25	Free CX Network Webinar Series	Valuable strategic intelligence on how global brands are shifting their customer experience outsourcing budgets.	Online	CX Network	cxnetwork.com
Mar 25-27	AgroWorld Uzbekistan 2026	Major domestic expo. IT Park uses this to connect resident AgTech startups with traditional agricultural conglomerates.	Tashkent, Uzbekistan *(Offline)*	Iteca Exhibitions	iteca.uz
Mar 26	Turkmenistan-EU Business Forum 2026	High-level trade forum. IT Park can observe EU digital trade policies extending into the Caspian/Central Asian corridor.	Ashgabat, Turkmenistan *(Offline)*	Int'l Trade Centre	intracen.org
Mar 27	National Technology Forum of Kazakhstan	The National Technology Forum of Kazakhstan *(Digital Qazaqstan)* is a major national technology event focused on innovation, artificial intelligence, digital economy, and Industry 5.0 development.	Shymkent city Qyzgaldaq Sarai *(Offline)*	Digital Qazaqstan platform *(with government & tech ecosystem support)*	https://digitalqazaqstan.kz/ru/#Program
RESIDENTS OF IT PARK UZBEKISTAN					
Date	**Event name**	**Description**	**Location**	**Event holder**	**Official Website**
Mar 16	Virtual Training: Implement Data Security with Purview	Learn to build targeted data loss protection measures with Microsoft Purview to ensure GDPR/CCPA compliance for export work.	Online	Microsoft Security	microsoft.com/events
Mar 16-17	Virtual Training: Create Agents in Copilot Studio	Learn to build and deploy custom AI agents in Copilot Studio to automate workflows	Online	Microsoft	microsoft.com/events

		and elevate SaaS offerings.			
Mar 17	Context Engineering for Self-Healing AI SRE	Advanced SRE methodologies utilizing AI to auto-correct infrastructure faults.	Online	Linux Foundation	linuxfoundation.org
Mar 17	Google Cloud Infrastructure for AWS Professionals	A highly technical cross-training session for cloud architects to bridge infrastructure skills between AWS and Google Cloud.	Online	Google Cloud	https://www.google.com/search?q=rsvp.withgoogle.com
Mar 17	MVP Program Essentials: What You Need to Know	Microsoft session explaining how top developers can achieve MVP status, boosting international credibility for resident experts.	Online	Microsoft	developer.microsoft.com
Mar 18	Practical Approaches to Interoperable Blockchain	Discusses cross-chain compatibility and smart contract engineering.	Online	Linux Foundation	linuxfoundation.org
Mar 18	AI & Process Automation: Spend to Measurable Value	An executive webinar on adopting AI in BPO workflows; ideal for Residents of IT Park to shape its "AI-ready workforce" marketing.	Online	Datamatics	https://www.google.com/search?q=datamatics.com
Mar 19	Build Agentic AI Solutions *(Session 1)*	Microsoft training on Semantic Kernel Agent Framework and Azure AI Foundry.	Online	Microsoft	microsoft.com/events
Mar 19	Int'l Conference on Infrastructure Planning and Smart Mobility	Technical conference covering backend logistics algorithms and urban IoT device integrations.	Osh, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com
Mar 19	Predictive Analytics & ML Models	Academic and applied deep dive into predictive data modeling algorithms.	Osh, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com

Mar 21	World Congress on IT and Computer Science	A broad technical congress allowing developers to benchmark against global engineering standards.	Brest, Belarus *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferenceineurope.org
Mar 22	Build Agentic AI Solutions *(Session 2)*	Second session for developers to master custom AI agent generation on Azure.	Online	Microsoft	microsoft.com/events
Mar 23	Blockchain and AI in International Business	AIB webinar investigating how these technologies are applied practically by global firms.	Online	AIB	aib.world
Mar 24	What's New: Connected ERP for Private Capital	Carta webinar analyzing backend financial tech systems and SaaS tools for venture capital.	Online	Carta	carta.com
Mar 25	Is your startup ready for fundraising?	Swiss Startup Association webinar teaching founders how to use AI to improve pitch metrics.	Online	Swiss Startup Assoc	swissstartupassociation.ch
Mar 26	betterCode() Clean Architecture 2026	Intensive software engineering conference focusing on maintainable, scalable codebases.	Online	IT Community	dev.events
Mar 26	Automating the Middle Office	Driving Digital Transformation in the Middle Office, exploring the data gap between assets for finance-oriented startups.	Online	Carta	carta.com
Mar 26-27	Node Congress	A massive virtual gathering for backend developers building scalable apps with Node.js.	Online	IT Community	dev.events

Mar 27	Smart Manufacturing Systems using Blockchain	Niche event for residents building industrial IoT and supply chain tracking software.	Baku, Azerbaijan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com
Mar 27	Int'l Conference on Environmental Materials and Engineering Practices	Hardware and software integration event for residents dealing in physical tech supply chains and manufacturing software.	Astana, Kazakhstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 27	Int'l Conference on Future-Oriented Teaching and Learning Strategies	An EdTech innovation forum to discover new market demands for digital tutoring and remote learning SaaS.	Astana, Kazakhstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
MINISTRY OF DIGITAL TECHNOLOGIES					
Date	**Event name**	**Description**	**Location**	**Event holder**	**Official Website**
Mar 17	Int'l Conference on Biology and Applied Science *(ICBAS)*	An academic event where the Ministry can explore data science and spatial technologies applied to regional agricultural monitoring.	Moscow, Russia *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 18	Breaking the barriers to digital transformation	Online roundtable by the UK Institution of Civil Engineers focusing on data, people, and standards in digital infrastructure, highly relevant for e-government projects.	UK *(Online)*	Institution of Civil Engineers *(ICE)*	ice.org.uk
Mar 18	AI & Process Automation: Spend to Measurable Value	An executive webinar on adopting AI in BPO workflows; ideal to shape its "AI-ready workforce" marketing.	*Online*	Datamatics	https://www.google.com/search?q=datamatics.com

Mar 19	Georgia Public Sector Cybersecurity Summit	Interactive sessions on building cyber-resilient organizations and protecting state data.	Atlanta, USA *(Offline)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com
Mar 19	Int'l Conf on GIS in Disaster Management	Discusses tech-driven risk reduction, highly relevant to the Ministry's Smart Nation initiatives.	Tashkent, Uzbekistan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 19	Spatial Data Infrastructure and Policy	Armenian summit on data policy, beneficial for harmonizing Central Asian data exchange systems.	Gyumri, Armenia *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 24	UK Ministry of Defence: Zodiac industry engagement	A high-level UK defense and tech supplier briefing. Useful for the Ministry to understand secure G2B (Government-to-Business) tech procurement.	UK *(Online)*	techUK	techuk.org
Mar 25	Fight Fraud, Waste and Abuse with AI	GovTech webinar demonstrating AI applications for auditing and securing public funds.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	webinars.govtech.com
Mar 25-26	Government Efficiency Summit 2026	Explores the intersection of automation, AI, and streamlined government operations.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com
Mar 25	North Carolina AI and Cybersecurity Symposium	Investigates policy overlaps between AI adoption and national security protocols.	Raleigh, USA *(Offline)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com

Mar 25-26	Tashkent Water Week 2026	A sector-specific event where the Ministry can explore IoT and digital monitoring for water resource management.	Tashkent, Uzbekistan *(Offline)*	Iteca Exhibitions	iteca.uz
Mar 26	Eligibility Decisions You Can Defend	Explores how AI-assisted systems improve accuracy and oversight in citizen service determinations.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	webinars.govtech.com
Mar 26	Securing the Cyber/Software Supply Chain	Virtual workshop equipping government officials to safeguard IT procurement and software assets.	USA *(Online)*	Digital Government Institute	digitalgovernment.com
Mar 27	National Technology Forum of Kazakhstan	The National Technology Forum of Kazakhstan *(Digital Qazaqstan)* is a major national technology event focused on innovation, artificial intelligence, digital economy, and Industry 5.0 development.	Shymkent city Qyzgaldaq Sarai *(Offline)*	Digital Qazaqstan platform *(with government & tech ecosystem support)*	https://digitalqazaqstan.kz/ru/#Program